

What Goes in the Report, and What Does Not

The forms, the thresholds, and the two things a home inspection report never contains.

Narrative report	A report written in paragraph form based on observations and opinions of the condition of the property.
Checklist or rating system	What a narrative report is combined with for a more complete picture of property condition. The narrative explains; the checklist guarantees nothing was skipped.
Disclaimer	NOT a home inspection report form. It is a clause inside a report, and it protects the home inspector.

YOU HAVE MISSED THIS 3 TIMES

Which of the following is NOT a home inspection report form?

Disclaimer.

YOU HAVE MISSED THIS 2 TIMES

A professional inspector delivers a report written in paragraph form based on observations and opinions of the condition of a subject property. This form of report is known as a:

Narrative report.

The reporting thresholds

YOU HAVE MISSED THIS 3 TIMES

Visible defects should be noted:

Where the condition is other than purely cosmetic.

That is the line. Anything affecting function, safety or durability goes in. Scuffed paint and a worn carpet do not. The phrase to hold is "other than purely cosmetic".

YOU HAVE MISSED THIS 4 TIMES

The home inspector is required to report the location of the:

Electric service equipment.

Missed four times. The client needs to know where to shut the power off, so its location is reported as a matter of course — not because it is defective, but because it is information the occupant needs on day one.

Code violations — the two questions that look the same

YOU HAVE MISSED THIS

Which of the following is NOT included in the home inspection report?

A list of all code violations.

YOU HAVE MISSED THIS

A home inspector is being sued because a minor code violation was found after the inspection and had not been reported. Which is TRUE?

Home inspectors are not required to uncover code violations.

A home inspection is a condition inspection, not a code compliance inspection. Codes change by jurisdiction and by year, and a house is judged against the code in force when it was built. Reporting conditions is your job; certifying code compliance is a code official's.

Two more limits

Design defects	Only licensed professional engineers can comment on design defects.
Carbon monoxide detectors absent	Note the information on the report if that state requires it, and suggest they be installed.
Not generally tested or monitored	Asked which of air quality, water quality and pest infestation a home inspector tests, the answer is all of them are outside it. Separate items, all excluded — a cumulative answer, not a competing one.
Priority statements	Describe conditions needing attention. A statement that the asphalt shingle roofing has a remaining life of 10 to 15 years is not a priority statement — it is a life expectancy, and nothing needs doing.

Say it back

Cover the page. Answer each one out loud.

1. What is a narrative report, and what is it combined with?
2. Is a disclaimer a report form? What is it, and who does it protect?
3. At what threshold is a visible defect noted?
4. Which location are you required to report?
5. Are you required to uncover code violations? Say why not.
6. Who may comment on design defects?
7. Which three things is an inspector not required to test?
8. Why is a roof life expectancy not a priority statement?